America, Reloading – A Program

By Harryette Mullen, Andrea Gibson, and Richard Blanco

We Are Not Responsible by Harryette Mullen

(Pg 77) We are not responsible for your lost or stolen relatives. We cannot guarantee your safety if you disobey our instructions. We do not endorse the causes or claims of people begging for handouts. We reserve the right to refuse service to anyone. Your ticket does not guarantee that we will honor your reservations. In order to facilitate our procedures, please limit your carrying on. Before taking off, please extinguish all smoldering resentments. If you cannot understand English, you will be moved out of the way. In the event of a loss, you'd better look out for yourself. Your insurance was cancelled because we can no longer handle your frightful claims. Our handlers lost your luggage and we are unable to find the key to your legal case. You were detained for interrogation because you fit the profile. You are not presumed to be innocent if the police have reason to suspect you are carrying a concealed

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wallet. It's not our fault you were born wearing a gang color. It is not our obligation to inform you of your rights. Step aside, please, while our officer inspects your bad attitude. You have no rights we are bound to respect. Please remain calm, or we can't be held responsible for what happens to you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Harryette Mullen
Book: Sleeping with the Dictionary, Pg 77
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Date (Month/Year): Feb 2002
also online at
https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/145281/we-are-not-responsible

INTRODUCTION

__We__ can't be held responsible. (Sigh) But until __we__ are ready to accept responsibility for the growing number of mass and school shootings in America -- until __we__ are ready to do more than offer thoughts and prayers -- __we__ will live in a society of petrified people, terrified children, followed only by the brief silence of . . .

America, Reloading – A Program with poems by Harryette Mullen, Andrea Gibson and Richard Blanco

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America, Reloading by Andrea Gibson

(Pg 51-54) Mostly because of dying stars,
scientists say space smells like barbecue
and gunpowder. Which is to say
space smells like the United States --

a holiday where we celebrate the independence
of machine guns, how anyone can buy
a cemetery at a sporting goods store
on their 18th birthday

and open carry it to an elementary school
where children are learning tears
don't fall in space. Weightless, without
gravity, they never leave the eye.

Is that what happens to the NRA?
they ask after they've watched the bodies
of half their class use every red crayon
in the universe to scream goodbye.

Do the NRA's tears not drop
because they're astronauts?

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How does a parent tell a 6-year-old
that gun sales spike every time
our right to bear massacres
makes a coroner faint,

makes a medical examiner say, ***I can't,***
my god, I can't.

But we can, can't we, America?
Each election, don't we say ***can***
stomach the boy loading a black hole
into his backpack and unloading it

in the high school hallway
on Valentine's Day? It would take
light years to count how many times
the terrified texted ***I LOVE YOU,***
I LOVE YOU, I LOVE YOU
in Parkland, Florida
while the NRA kept crying
in space.

My friend, a second grade teacher,
is instructed to practice hiding her children

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in the closet. Twenty-three 7-year-olds
huddle holding their breath.

Holding your breath in space
is the fastest way to die.

The lungs explode in that vacuum
almost as quickly as an AR-15
can make blood-dust
of a closet door.

Of the twenty children murdered at Sandy Hook,
not one of them needed an ambulance.
That's how dead they were.
That's how well the Second Amendment works.

Because there is no air, it is silent in space.
But not as silent as the Christians
on the Senate floor while twenty more families
are asked if they would like to talk

to a priest. Christ could tear the nails
from his hands and scrape them down
a shrapnel-battered chalkboard
and they'd still be praying for their bank accounts.

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After Columbine, parents were notified
About their children in tiny conference rooms.
One family said, ***We could hear the family before us screaming, and we knew we were next.***

Now loved ones check Facebook
to see who is dead. A mother's status is, **I CAN'T REACH MY DAUGHTER. I CAN'T REACH MY DAUGHTER.** Decades after her child is slaughtered

in the cafeteria
that thought will still be
tearing her from her bed -- **I CAN'T REACH MY DAUGHTER –**

The footprints left by astronauts
on the moon are permanent.
They will never ever go away
like the grief of a father

identifying his son by his shoes
because the rest of his son's body
was out-lobbied by the NRA, by suits
whispering into the ears of Washington –

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this is what we mean
by freedom and justice, the names
of our cities becoming synonymous
with babies being buried

like seeds in the greed gardens of the wealthy.
But you should know your teacher
was a hero, we say, her body was found
bunkering a group of your friends.

And that's as happy as the ending gets
right now. The heroes almost always dead.
The flag at half mass grave.
Children huddled

in basements, trying to tear off their ears
on the Fourth of July because the fireworks
sound like the day everyone died crying,
died with gravity pouring

their next 80 birthdays from their eyes,
while America reloaded,
and moved on
to the next.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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Seventeen Funerals by Richard Blanco

(Pg 63) Seventeen suns rising in seventeen bedroom windows. Thirty-four eyes blooming open with the light of one more morning. Seventeen reflections in the bathroom mirror. Seventeen backpacks or briefcases stuffed with textbooks or lesson plans. Seventeen ***good mornings*** at kitchen breakfasts and seventeen ***goodbyes*** at front doors. Seventeen drives through palm-lined streets and miles of crammed highways to Marjory Stoneman Douglas High School at 5901 Pine Island Road. The first bell ringing-in one last school day on February fourteenth, 2018. Seventeen echoes of footsteps down hallways for five class periods: algebra, poetry, biology, art, history. Seventeen hands writing on whiteboards or taking notes at their desks until the first gunshot at 2:21pm. One AR-15 rifle in the hands of a nineteen-year-old mind turning hate for himself into hate for others, into one hundred fifty bullets fired in six minutes

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through building number twelve. Seventeen dead carried down hallways they walked, past cases of trophies they won, flyers for clubs they belonged to, lockers they won't open again. Seventeen Valentine's Day dates broken and cards unopened. Seventeen bodies to identify, dozens of photo albums to page through and remember their lives. Seventeen caskets and burial garments to choose for them. Seventeen funerals to attend in twelve days. Seventeen graves dug and headstones placed—all marked with the same date of death. Seventeen names: Alyssa. Helena. Scott. Martin—seventeen absentees forever—Nicholas. Aaron. Jamie. Luke—seventeen closets to clear out—Christopher. Cara. Gina. Joaquin—seventeen empty beds—Alaina. Meadow. Alex. Carmen. Peter—seventeen reasons to rebel with the hope these will be the last seventeen to be taken by one of *three-hundred-ninety-three-million guns in America. ***They were not***

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2023 National Qualifier - MS

For more statistical data about school shootings, see the K-12 School Shooting Database at https://k12ssdb.org/

**** Statistic confirmed at How Many Gun Owners are in America (2024 Statistics) on 8/9/2024 https://ammo.com/articles/how-many-gun-owners-in-america#:~:text=Based%20on%20NICS%20background%20data,owned%20firearms%20in%20the%20U.S.***

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